

My Late Father's Correspondence



PLAIN TEXT VERSION

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The game is presented in both cursive and plain text versions for easier reading.

This is the plain text version.

This document contains all the days and letters of the game in an easy-to-read format. Start with the cursive version of the game, and if you have any trouble reading it, you can refer to this version, or use both concurrently if that is easier.

CONTENT NOTICE

This game includes content relating to grief, patriarchy, illness, colonialism, war and death.

My Late Father's Correspondence

A READ & REPLY GAME



STORYBREWERS
ROLEPLAYING

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Nov 29, 1832

Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire, England.

Your name is Agatha Lockley. You are the younger child of the retired Col. Thomas Lockley. You are yet unmarried, and live in your childhood and ancestral home, Eadly Hall. Your father passed away in that very home three weeks ago. You do not stand to inherit it.

Your father's funeral has come and gone. Now, you are the only one in residence at Eadly Hall.

That is all you need to know for now—the rest is for you to discover and imagine.



Day 1

Nov 29, 1832

I have not been into father's study since he passed. His reading glasses are still perched on the edge of the small mahogany desk, as if he had just taken them off to rub the bridge of his nose before asking me to hand him the next of his letters. Though his study has not become mine, his letters have. I had best see what my aunt has written me.

[One letter sits upon the desk, the postmarks read T.P. Piccadilly, and Paid 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 1A

[Written on mourning stationery with a black border in black ink. The handwriting is relatively neat and orderly with a familiar flourish.]

London, Nov 28th 1832.

My darling Aggie,

I hope the days after the funeral weren't too trying. It is one thing to face the endless stream of condolences about your father's death when you have your dearest aunt by your side, but it's quite another thing to be left in that big great house all by yourself. I write with tragic news, I am to be delayed in London. With your older brother Nicholas so long *away*, and thus absconded from all duties and responsibilities, the business of executing your father's estate is far more of a mess than I could have imagined. I have, of course, written to his last address and the one before that, as no doubt have you—I am not however too hopeful he will suddenly appear in London in readiness for the responsibilities of inheritance. Nevertheless, I am duty bound to do all I can to find him before anything else can be resolved, so I am doing what I must.

In the meantime, you shall have to see to the running of the estate and handle the barrages of the many well-wishers. These are both tasks I know you are most capable of, but are tiresome nevertheless. Perhaps most tedious of all, it's imperative that you open and reply to all the various correspondences that will now come flooding in—those for yourself, and most especially, those addressed to your father.

Your butler, Mr Alder will bring the letters to you each morning—take them, and let them sit on your desk for just a moment. Take a breath, and then when you are ready, read and reply to each. It is crucial that you reply to all correspondence on the day of its arrival, as at this important time matters are best taken care of swiftly. You hardly need me to tell you this, but be considered in your response as there are delicate matters afoot.

My dear, you know people will say all kinds of things in their letters—of you and your father both. You'll do well to remember that is merely their opinion, and take it with a grain of salt. It is all too common people misremember or their prejudices come to the forefront. Except for me of course, I am your favourite aunt and therefore right about everything!

I know you and your father did not always see eye to eye. He could be a difficult man in his own way. But we all have our moods, and he loved you through each and every one of them that overtook him. At any rate, some of his acquaintances shall be vital to your place in society now he is gone. Especially as you are 23 and yet unmarried you may find yourself calling on them for favours in the future. Not that now is a time to think about such things—heavens, you are in mourning!

Look after yourself my dearest, keep well, and I shall be back as soon as I can—heaven willing with your brother in tow, but heaven may indeed not will it! Write to me now even if briefly and do assure me you are well.

Your loving aunt,
Gertrude Allington

Day 2

Nov 31, 1832

The circulars, military journals, and nature periodicals are still piling up. I must see to that before the desk is lost entirely. Aunt has paid the mail charge again which is kind of her, though it really ought to be left for Eadly.

[Two letters sit upon the desk, underneath them is a pile of old circulars and periodicals.

2A: The postmarks read Paid At Glasgow and Add ½. It is addressed to Nicholas and Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.

2B: The postmarks read T.P. Piccadilly, and Paid 8x2. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 2A

[Written on cream watermarked stationery in black ink. The handwriting is rather large and self-assured.]

Glasgow, Nov 27th 1832.

My Dear Sir and Madam,

I wager you do not remember me, though I certainly remember you both! The last time we met Nicholas was a tiny boy of six quite obsessed with painting everything, and Miss Agatha, you were a plump, bright thing of the age of three—and very charming, I assure you.

I write with a heavy heart to hear news of your father's passing. I count myself among your father's oldest friends from his time in service. I knew him before he was even made a cornet, and I consider myself to have the privilege of knowing him inside and out. You may not know this, but when we first met your father had joined my unit of dragoons as a "gentleman volunteer"—that's what they called them back then—men from good families too poor to buy their first commission, waiting to be given one by merit or connections. Even then, he had a way of devoting himself to those around him that was admirable.

You have no doubt heard the story of how he received his first commission, and the unfortunate French captain who mistook him for a member of his own side after the cavalry's uniform changed. The story of how he received his promotion to captain was less glamorous—he simply worked hard until his turn arrived—but in many ways it was more characteristic of him.

Despite what others say, I do not think your father loved war in the way everyone seems to suppose. He certainly drew satisfaction from a well-executed manoeuvre, and he was renowned as a very skillful leader, but I do not think he loved it. Rather, I believe he felt at home there, in the small world of his regiment, where he was in a way a sort of father to the boys around him. He said to me once “they’re good lads” and the way he said it betrayed a fondness more keen than the simple assessment of one’s troops. Every loss at the Battle of Morales was hard for him I know, but he certainly inflicted far more back at the French.

But I have gone on too long for a letter of condolences. I hope both of you are faring as well as expected and are keeping on as your father would have wanted. I remember his face on the day Nicholas was born. He looked like a man struck by the discovery of a duty more grand than any he thought possible. He was a good, dear friend, and if I might assist his lovely children it would be my honour.

I remain,

Yours faithfully,

Maj. Gen. John Weatherton
2nd Dragoon Guards

Letter 2B

[Written on mourning stationery with a black border
in black ink. The handwriting is your aunt's.]

2B

London, Nov 30th 1832.

My dearest Aggie,

You are ever reliable my darling! But please do take care of yourself as well as the estate.

You will never guess who I have run into here in London— young Mr Rajiv Hughes, the ward of your father's friend. You would not have seen him since he left to study in Oxford. Do you remember he used to visit every summer when you and Nicholas were younger? He never got on well with Nicholas, but you two were practically inseparable. We all recall the time you put on that little play together—what was it called?

Mr Hughes is returning to Habershire and offered to call on you and keep you company. I think it proper since he is an old family friend, and of course Mr Alder will be there. Should I tell him to come, or would you like me to ask him to write first?

Mr Hughes is returning to Habershire and offered to call on you and keep you company. I think it proper since he is an old family friend, and of course Mr Alder will be there. Should I tell him to come, or would you like me to ask him to write first?

As well as that, there is the need to handle some of your father's effects from his rented London residence. In Nicholas' absence, I think you are best placed to decide what to do with each. The lawyers said we can have each effect

sent to Eadly Hall,
stored here in London,
donated to charity or
destroyed as appropriate.

Let me know your wishes as regards to each.

Your loving aunt,
Gertrude Allington

[Enclosed within your aunt's letter is a further letter from the estate's solicitors Blackstone & Associates. It is printed on their business letterhead. It is stamped James F Stuart solicitor at the top. Your aunt has annotated some of the listed items.]

London, Nov 29th 1832

Dear Sir or Madam,

Please advise on the disposal of the following effects found at the London residence of Thomas Lockley:

Jewellery. Silver cravat pin with pearl inlaid, gold plated cravat pin, cufflinks with painted peacocks, cufflinks with painted gardenias, shirt studs. A women's ring, inlaid with amethyst and freshwater pearl engraved in the interior, T.L O.L. A necklace of cut steel and paste gems in a case labelled 'Hennell' with a purple ribbon around it.

Portrait. Half-length, 44 x 34 in. A woman in her early twenties with dark hair, green eyes holds a small baby boy to her chest. Plaque reads Olivia Lockley, as commissioned by Thomas Lockley and painted by Augustus Glenford, 1806.

*Aunt: Your mother looks so happy here,
I hope you will hang it somewhere nice.*

Clothes. Shirts, cravets, coats, vests, pants, shoes and two top hats.

Aunt: Your father's taste was a little out of date, although in my view still quite acceptable for a man of his age and position.

Papers. A small number of letters to and from various doctors in London. Many loose pages (perhaps intended as a journal?) accounts of various battles, accounts of various birds desc. and locations where said birds were seen, their colouring. A bill for one necklace from Hennell & Co dated last month.

Port. Many ordinary bottles such as could be purchased at any store. Three with faded labels that are likely of value, Cockburn 1812, Sandeman 1806, Yeatman 1792.

Figurines. Painted calvary figures.

Aunt: Your father's regiment, the 18th Royal Hussars. He painted meticulously. On the bottom of the bases, I found the name of some of his military friends. One reads Lt. Col George Hughes. One is of himself—it's quite a good likeness.

Medals. Waterloo Medal 1815, Long Service Medal, Badge of the 18th Royal Hussars.

Aunt: The most impressive, kept in London for events no doubt. The rest are in your father's room at Eadly. He never did like to talk to me about the stories behind them.

Locket. Silver, half a palm in length, attached to a chain. Inside is pictured a woman in her 40s, brown hair, eyes staring straight at the viewer. Signed with painter's name and year: George Cooper, 1828.

Aunt: Do you know who this is? I'm afraid I've no idea.

Bird statues. Many, difficult to transport. Three most notable:
Peacock - carved wood, half life-sized, ornately painted.
Honey buzzard - stone, 2ft in height and 4ft in wingspan, unpainted.
Bluethroat - curved wood, 3 inches in height, painted in exacting detail.

We have the honour to be,
Your most obedient servants,
James F. Stuart
Blackstone & Associates

Day 3

Dec 5, 1832

No matter how much this room is aired, it continues to smell of paint and old tobacco. Opening father's mail still leaves me with a trace of unease, like a child who has snuck their hand into Cook's pastries before they are served.

[Two letters sit upon the desk.

3A: The postmarks read Roma, A.DE.1.1832, and two charge marks of 1/10 and 8. It is addressed to Col. Thomas Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.

3B: The postmarks read T.P. Piccadilly, and Paid 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 3A

[Written in black ink on cream paper.

The handwriting is a rather irregular scrawl,
perhaps a touch careworn.]

Rome, Nov 20. 1832.

My dear Sir,

Here are his latest slew of expenses. Do you wish me to arrange payment as usual? For such a prudent man you truly have raised an extravagant son. I don't know why you continue paying for him—let the boy fend for himself for a month or two, and he'll certainly understand the meaning of responsibility. I've been telling you for years you are too soft on him, and this is where it has ended up. Can you imagine what he will be like as master of Eadly Hall?

I've no concept what your girl is up to, but I hope it is a bit more appropriate. You may complain she is too sensitive but which would you prefer?

If you're worried about your health then come here. The continental life and colour will do you good and you can wrangle your son yourself. You know how much Olivia loved it here, and in Florence also—before the war took hold at least. You two always looked so inescapably English no matter how hard you tried!

Although if you ask me it is retirement that has been the real trouble. You never were happier than when you had something to do. Something real to do, not just the dull business of a gentleman nodding off while his Steward manages his estate.

At any rate, I have given you my counsel and I'm sure you will ignore it as usual.

Your friend,
Matthew Summers

Inside the letter are bills for expenses from the last three months from Florence — hotels, dinners, galleries and shows, paint and canvas, clothes, the occasional house of ill repute. These have been grouped and listed out by Matthew by date. Around one month ago, an expense began for the rent of a long-term residence on via Federuci Tozzzi. At the top Matthew has written: "Look at all this! Totals £120 for just three months!!"

Letter 3B

[Written on mourning stationery with a black border
in black ink. The handwriting is your aunt's.]

3B

London, Dec 2nd 1832.

My dearest Aggie,

It has been done as you have described, those of your father's effects you wished sent to Eadly you will find arrived with this letter. As I was looking through his papers I found this letter from Nicholas. I've enclosed it in case it is helpful in tracking him down. However, it seems to be one of his old return addresses.

As for me, I am counting down the days until I can return to Habershire. As executor of your father's will, I am sadly stuck here in London until all reasonable attempts have been made to find your brother. At that point, I am told we can seek an order from the court to have your father's will resolved as if your brother himself was dead (quite shocking, I hope it doesn't come to that).

In the meantime darling, it brings me much comfort to know you shall have company from Captain Rajiv Hughes, as I have now heard he is. He told me he intends to be in Habershire within the next two weeks. He has been away rather a long time, perhaps you can show him what's changed (if anything has changed, you know Habershire!) Col. Hughes has passed, I'm sad to say, and as he had no natural children, Captain Hughes inherited his Habershire estate. Yet he told me he hasn't been there since he was twelve! It will be strange for him I am sure.

Yours affectionately,
Gertrude Allington

Inside is a scrap from a letter from Nicholas: torn off and folded over. On one side is the return address in Florence. A fragment on the reverse side reads:

“we both ought to do what we want father, that's how happiness is made whatever you might say. We'll do it anyway, so there's no sense being burdened with guilt.”

Day 4

Dec 9, 1832

How strange it was to have Alder press a note from the staff into my hands this morning—he said he would be kindly obliged were I to read it. How quickly he departed once I had taken it.

[Two letters sit upon the desk.

4A: The letter has not been posted. It has been folded in half, and the outside reads “Mdm for your kind attention.”

4B: The postmarks read T.P. Lombard St, and Paid 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcote, Habershire. The handwriting is new to you.]

Letter 4A

[Written in black ink on a single brown cut sheet. The handwriting is slanted and tightly crammed in.]

Dear Madam,

With Col. Lockley no longer with us (bless his soul), myself and Mr Alder would like to know whether you'd like to make any changes to the day to day running of the house? As you would recall, Col. Lockley had some requirements around the closing of curtains, timing of meals, and other matters that may no longer suit you. We've known you many years Madam, and we all wish you to be as comfortable as possible in these difficult times, so please don't hesitate to ask us.

We also wanted to ask about the menu for the week. As you requested we have dispensed with formal dinners when there's no guests, since there's just yourself about. We did wonder what you might like instead. Mary told us you'd not asked for anything cooked the last few nights. Is there anything you'd find suitable? Sammy's into the village every day now with all the mail back and forth, so he can pick up anything you wish. Mrs Preston does a great lamb roast—she's not made it because Col. Lockley did not enjoy lamb—but perhaps you might try it? Also we've heard there might be guests afoot?

We remain madam,

Yr most obt servts,

E. Stuart and M. Alder

Letter 4B

[Written in black ink on a large cream page.
The handwriting is large and looping, flowing with a
certain dynamic, energetic quality to it.]

4B

London
Dec 8th, 1832.

Dear Miss Lockley,

Your aunt told me that I might call upon you when I return to Habershire next week. It will be a delight to restore our acquaintance after so many years.

Your aunt has said you are short on good company, and in truth I am the same, especially with Christmas so close approaching. It is my first return to Habershire since my guardian's death in India (Col. Hughes—a friend of your fathers, do you remember him?) Now I've reached the age of majority, I have inherited Caldwell House. It is currently being opened on my account. I intend to live in it, at least for a while until I am called back into service. It will be strange to be back there without him and after all these years.

If visiting you alone was not too much of an imposition, I must admit that I had asked your aunt if I might see your father's collection of military figures. She kindly obliged. I found seeing them quite moving in a way. Did you know he had painted his own regiment, the 18th Royal Hussars? I knew them instantly when I saw

them. The Royal Hussars are easily recognised for their uniforms—dark blue with yellow braiding. He had painted my father too. If you do not have other plans for it, perhaps I might give that particular figurine a home in Caldwell House?

I'm not sure if he told you, but your father came to see me after my guardian passed away—this was in London three years ago, shortly before I left for Gibraltar. He gave his condolences, but he also left me his advice, of sorts. He said that military men grow callous of death, but to do so was to doom one's judgement. The way to be a good officer was to feel each death acutely, yet act on none individually. That, he said, is how to excel—and yet, he added, it leaves a bitter taste in your mouth to do so, a sort of taste that lingers with you long after retirement. Strange advice I think. Fortunately, none of the men under my command have suffered further than a broken leg!

But enough of those passed onwards for now. You must tell me something of yourself, though no doubt I will find out much more when I visit. I remember our little games and stories with much fondness. I still write poetry I must admit, although it is quite as awful as it was back then! A lot of our adventures blur as childhood memories do, but I have a strange one that comes back to me. I insisted we dress as hideous ghosts to try to get Nicholas to atone for a crime of having painted your toy horse a horrible red (?) colour—he was not scared but we did terrify Mrs Stuart. Is she still with you? I suppose I will also have to think further about household staff myself.

At any rate, I will see you shortly, I will bring a marvellous ginger cake I have become far too fond of in London. We shall talk more then.

Yours sincerely,
Capt. Rajiv Hughes

Day 5

Dec 12, 1832

How odd that a letter should be hand delivered by footman all the way from London. It has been scented with perfume—jasmine? Alder told me the footman was most reluctant to hand it over to anyone but my father—of course the impossibility of that eventually convinced him to do otherwise. He waits downstairs now for my reply.

[Two letters sit upon the desk.

5A: The letter has not been posted. It has been folded in quarters, and the outside reads “Thomas Lockley” in violet ink. The paper is embossed with a floral pattern.

5B: The postmark reads Habershire DE8 1832, and the charge mark is 4. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 5A

[Written on embossed floral stationery in violet ink.

Pictures of flowers adorn the paper.

The handwriting is dainty and warm.]

My darling Thomas,

I won't argue with you about it any more. With your state being what it is, can you really expect me to stay here in London while only the Lord knows what's happening to you in Milcot? What if things worsen? What if something were to happen to you while I am not there? I could not bear such a thing.

No, I am packing, and I will be there within the week. I have a distant cousin I can claim to be visiting. I'm sure scrutiny in the countryside cannot be as dreadful as you've imagined. At any rate, even if we must pretend to be distant acquaintances I should have the good fortune of looking into your eyes once more.

Stop worrying about what will happen if I come, and start to think about the good you will experience from my being there! Surely I shall be the best balm for body and soul one could hope for, quite above what any doctor has recommended you. And heavens, don't worry about your daughter finding out, I'm sure she has better things to do with her time than spy on her father. Shouldn't she be looking for a match by now? Perhaps you ought to send her to London for the rest of the season—then we should be undisturbed.

I've sent up Mattias should you wish to send me word back about anything before I depart. Don't try to change my mind you won't succeed.

I love you darling,

I shall be with you before long.

Letter 5B

[Written neatly in blue ink by a practised, elegant hand. A picture of a bird adorns the letterhead.]

5B

Habershire, Dec 8th 1832.

Dear Sir and Madam,

We write with great condolences upon the passing of your father, who was one of the biggest supporters of the Habershire Birdwatching Association. We thank your family for his generous bequest of £100. As an expression of thanks for his significant contribution to the Association in life and beyond it, we wish to invite you to be the guests of honour at the annual holiday season gala of the Association on 18th December. It would be our pleasure to have you attend. I look forward to hearing your response.

Yours faithfully,
Sarah Williams

[Enclosed is a printed invitation to the annual gala of
the Habershire Birdwatching Association.]

5B

Annual Gala

“As birds, our wishes fly”

The Company of
[handwritten] Mr/s Nicholas & Agatha Lockley and guests
is requested to attend the
Habershire Birdwatching Association Ball, at Capt. Knowles’ Hall
on Tuesday 18th of Dec current, at 5 o’clock p.m.

Managers:
S. Williams
Z. Lovall
H. Warren

Habershire, Dec. 1832

END OF DAY 5

Day 6

Dec 19, 1832

An unpaid letter sent all the way from Florence. I would recognise that hand anywhere, and most especially when it has scrawled my own name. Perhaps a glass of claret before I open this one.

[One letter sits upon the desk,
6A: The postmarks read Firenze, and A DE.12 1832.
The charge marks read 1/10 and 8. It is addressed
to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.
There is a small illustration of a butterfly.]

Letter 6A

[Written in blue ink, as if dashed off quickly.
The handwriting is bold and angular, and there are
many crossed out mistakes peppered throughout.]

Florence Dec 9. 1832

My dear sister,

I'd gone to pick up father's money order from the post office, and instead I received a letter from Mr Summers saying that father had passed away. I am quite shocked in truth. I didn't even know his illness had taken a turn for the worse. I suppose that is my own fault, but you know what it was like when I wrote him—nothing but nonsense about responsibility and the estate and not a word about his actual life.

I suppose you might tell me the state of things. Mr Summers was very vague on the details. Did father keep me in his will or did he do what he threatened before I left and truly disinherit me? At any rate, I thought you might ask our aunt to send some funds to tide me over? It's an odd awkward situation, you being at Eadly, and me being here with little idea what is happening back there.

I've not a great want to return to Eadly to deal with it all. Not only would it take me a week or two to get there from Florence (I'm in Florence now) and a great deal of expense might I add, but I've just taken up a proper rental here which would have to be dealt with, and there's all my paintings and supplies to think about. Besides, you know with all those relatives visiting who disapprove of me, you don't want me around anyway.

The truth is Aggie, I've met someone. Someone born here in Florence. It's funny, they barely spoke a word of English when we met and my Italian was certainly in dire need of improvement, and yet a connection was there. A connection was instantly there and I knew it and felt from the first moment. They're a great painter in their own right too. I am learning from them with every day that

passes, I feel my mind expanding and my abilities growing—it is the missing piece in the puzzle I’ve been looking for. I don’t want to leave it all, not now anyway.

Aggie, I know you might have felt like you got the rotten lot where father is concerned. You know that father and I did not exactly get along, and sometimes you were certainly caught in the middle of that, which I regret. But you were always so good at managing the estate, and managing him if you needed to, there hardly seemed a point in my being there to step in and antagonise him further. At any rate he’s passed now, and it’s time for us to live our own lives as we will.

How are you keeping anyway? Are you married yet yourself? Did father find you a nice army boy? I hope things are tolerable there and not as dire as it all sounds.

Your brother faithfully,
Nicholas

On the side of the paper is written: I’ve drawn you a little of my life

At the bottom of the paper are some sketches: a man in casual and relaxed clothing, a bust of a man wearing what seems to be a theatre costume or outfit, and a sketch of a Florence landscape.

Day 7

Dec 21, 1832

After more than a month, the key has been found to the locked drawer of father's desk. There was nothing inside but Nicholas' old return addresses and a locket portrait of mama. The locket is scratched and part of it is bent—I think it is the same one he took when he was posted in France. I'll place it by my inkwell—mama can watch over me while I answer today's correspondence.

[Two letters sit upon the desk, along with a key.

7A: The letter has not been posted. It has been folded in half, and is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall.

7B: The postmarks read T.P. Piccadilly, and Paid 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 7A

[Written in black ink instead of violet this time, on an unadorned page.]

Dear Madam,

I thank you for the courtesy of replying to my prior letter, my footman shall await your next one. Having now been made aware of your father's passing, it grieves me greatly. I shall be travelling to St George on the Hill to visit his grave and say my goodbyes.

I do believe you are in possession of my locket, if you would be so kind to give it to my footman. I feel honesty demands me to tell you that I intend to leave it at your father's grave, but do not fear, I will do so in a way that ensures it cannot be seen.

As for what you might imagine passed between your father and myself, if it will aggrieve you in any way, then I assure nothing happened and I bid you cease to read my letter here. Otherwise read on at your own peril.

The page ends at this point, giving you a chance to choose not to read onwards.

Your father and I met by chance in Vauxhall gardens, where I had gone to try to and recapture some feeling of joy in my life after my husband's passing. I saw him strolling some several yards behind the friends he was with—they were taken up with conversation but he was a watcher of the world. I introduced myself, quite a rude thing to do I suppose, and we walked some way together. I found him to be solemn but charming, I enjoyed the depth of emotion I saw within him, a contrast from the many shallow men life has seen fit to offer me.

We continued our acquaintance at several cafes, the theatre (which he did not enjoy), the concert hall (which he did), and then eventually we continued our acquaintance in a different way.

I have never known a man so thoughtful as your father in the right company. When we met he was watching me, always aiming to understand my intentions, determine my needs. He liked to be alone when the mood struck him and I respect that. But when he was with me he made me feel as if he listened to my conversation for its own sake, and for no reason but that. It was a feeling that is too rare to find in this world.

At one point we considered marriage, but we were quite happy as we were. Free from the trappings and conventions it would put upon us.

As I said, I thank you for the courtesy you have shown me in replying. Given the nature of the connection between us, I think it's best I do not reveal my true name, but allow me to sign off with the respect two women owe one another. I learned much about you and your brother from your father. He spoke of you with great fondness, if with a sense of ignorance about your true thoughts and intentions in life. He said there was much about you that reminded him of your mother. I hope that is something you would wish to hear.

Letter 7B

[Written on mourning stationery with a black border in black ink. The handwriting is your aunt's.]

7B

London, Dec 20th 1832.

My darling Aggie,

You will not believe what has happened! I have heard from Nicholas! He said that he received my letters all at once, having finally visited the post office to check for correspondence from the family sent to his old residences. He gave me his current address.

Nicholas said he may return to Eadly at some point in the future, but has asked me to remit the funds from the will into his account in the interim. Technically that is possible, the lawyers could arrange it, but I'd rather him come back, see to the care of the estate, and have things done properly. Still I am truly most sensitive to your needs in this situation—what would you prefer I do? I can delay the transfer of the funds for a few weeks if you would like, after that I am bound by law to make the transfer. At least once the transfer has been made I can return to Habershire to keep you company!

Once the funds are transferred your allowance will be dependent on Nicholas, though it would be a very uncharitable thing should he decide to alter it in any way. You do have a dowry provided in the will. It is £4000, which is equal to some £160 a year, a well enough amount to satisfy, say, an army gentleman of £1000 a year (not that I am thinking of Capt. Hughes! Although, since I'm on the topic, how are you finding him?). Still, I think one way or another things will surely be resolved, and that at least gives me some peace.

But on to cheerier topics, the Habershire Christmas Ball awaits in just a few days! How are preparations? You have certainly been in mourning long enough for it to be perfectly acceptable for you to add some silks and trimmings to your black attire. I do hope you will be able to have some fun, truly you deserve some my dear.

Yours with great affection,
Gertrude Allington

Day 8

Jan 3, 1833

What does one do with reams and reams of old papers? All the important documents are already in the custody of solicitors. What remains in here is boxes of letters, receipts, reminders, annotated periodicals, and the occasional note to himself. A lifetime of thoughts carefully filed one day at a time.

[Two letters sit upon the desk:

8A: The postmarks read Firenze, and A DE28 1832. The charge marks read 1/10 and 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire. There is a small illustration of a butterfly.

8B: The letter has not been posted. It has been folded in the conventional way for a letter, and is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 8A

[Written in blue ink, in Nicholas' angular scrawl. There is, inexplicably, a pencil sketch of a duck with wings outstretched on the bottom of the page.]

Florence Dec 20th 1832.

My dear sister,

Merry Christmas, or so it will have been by the time this reaches you. Since your last letter I've been thinking a lot about things with you, and Eadly Hall. Aunt Gertrude has also written me, so I'm now fully apprised of the situation.

Here are things as they stand. While I do intend to claim my inheritance, I'm not well positioned to live in Eadly Hall, either in practicalities or in temperament. Truthfully, I am also aware that my current companion is ill-suited to accompanying me back home. You know how the English can be terribly prudish about so many things.

With all this in mind, I want you to know I intend to stay in Florence, if I can anyhow. You are so good at managing the estate so I had thought maybe things could simply keep on going as they are — until you get married of course. I imagine that might be some relief for you, to know nothing need change at Eadly Hall? As to the matter of Eadly's expenses, Aunt knows the details of the accounts, you can simply arrange it with her. Send any paperwork to Mr Summers and I shall sign it from here. Everything shall go along quite swimmingly.

I do intend to send for father's bird statues though, should they be still in our possession. I'd like to think of them as his artistic side. I might even imagine myself as an ornately carved heron. Perhaps someday I will finally break free from the thick stone that encases our family and take flight. One day I would like it if you should come to visit me here — but not too soon I imagine as there must still be quite a bit that needs tending to. In the meantime, I promise I shall write.

Your beloved brother,
Nicholas

Letter 8B

[Written in black ink on cream paper.

The handwriting is Rajiv's.]

8B

Habershire

Jan 2, 1833.

Dear Miss Lockley,

I thank you for your kindness in hosting me at Eadly Hall on the new year! It was quite a relief not to spend it alone at Caldwell House. We had both endured years greatly lacking in merriment, I am glad that together we seemed to find it in its final hours.

Seeing you at Eadly inspired within me a strange sense of displaced nostalgia. It is the same house in which you and I played so often many years ago, yet our place within it has changed. I recall my guardian and your father sitting in the very seats we sat, trimming cigars and drinking port. At the time I thought them the very pinnacle of what men could be — sons in their youth always think such things about their fathers. I cannot recall what they talked about, but I am sure it was very different to the sentiments we shared over ginger cake and claret.

As you know I became the ward of Col. Hughes when I was but three years old. When the world looked at us, they always assumed a distance between us. I was his ward, not his son, not a part of his real family. They thought, I imagined, that I could not truly know him, and he could not truly care for me. Yet to me, he was everything a father might be and more. He not only gave me guidance and opportunity, but a great affection that grounded me through any hardships life saw fit to offer. The greatest compliment he ever gave me was to say I had grown very like him, and I still find myself considering what actions he would take, whether as a Captain or even as a man.

I hope I do not presume too much when I observe that the situation between you and your father was very different. I remember when we were children, everyone used to say that Nicholas took after your mother, and you took after your father. When you both would spend far too long at carnival games trying to win, or when you both woke up early to see the world gently wake, everyone would say you were truly cut from the same cloth. Yet from what I learned from you, it seems that you became very different people as time went on. I know you laboured deeply under your father's expectations. I wonder how you will consider his stories and advice now that you are no longer bound to follow it.

It is snowing again, yet I find the weather more inviting than hostile. Perhaps the part of me that wishes to have little adventures has been reawakened. If you do not object, I should like to continue to call on you. I hope to be in Habershire for some months before I must again depart for service.

Yours faithfully,
Capt. Rajiv Hughes

Day 9

Jan 6, 1833

Almost two months of mail and I have finally seen fit to leave my own letter writing set permanently on top of father's mahogany desk. I need not move it for anyone it seems. Not for a long time.

[Two letters sit upon the desk.

9A: The postmarks read T.P. Piccadilly, and Paid 8. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.

9B: The postmark reads Birmingham JA3 1833 G., and there is a charge mark of 9. It is addressed to Agatha Lockley, Eadly Hall, Milcot, Habershire.]

Letter 9A

[Written on mourning stationery with a black border in black ink. The handwriting is your aunt's.]

London, Jan 5th 1833.

Darling Aggie,

It is finally done. Ownership and funds have been transferred, paperwork has been signed, countersigned, and then signed again, and my duties as executor of your father's estate have come to an end. I shall be returning home to Habershire within the week, and I shall be glad to see it, and of course you! It is well we can put this behind us, grieve our grieving, and look towards a brighter day.

You have been exceptional in the management of the estate, and it seems little is to change in that regard — does such a thought make you feel lighter or heavier? Of course you will have me nearby, and I hope I can ease the burden somewhat.

There was a parade of hussars today in London (the Prince's own I think) that made me think of your father. I remember the first time he put on that blue uniform, that ridiculous uniform with the yellow braids, he seemed instantly at home in it, and you couldn't help but think him capable of great things. Yet, and perhaps this is a foolish thing only a woman would say, greatness ought to begin with a great love for one's family. I believe he had such a love, I will always be a little sad that he could never quite show it.

But let's turn our attention to happier topics! What news from Habershire?

With kind love, and anticipation of my return,

Yours faithfully,
Gertrude Allington

Letter 9B

[Written in black ink on cream paper.

The handwriting is an orderly and flowing longhand
expansively arranged on the page.]

9B

Birmingham, Jan 3rd 1833.

Dear Madam,

My condolences on the passing of your father. Shortly before his passing he commissioned me to paint a portrait of himself for the gallery at Eadly Hall. He said the portrait there now is of him as a young man, and he should like it to show a face that has been through life instead. The commission for the work has been paid upfront, and I had already met with him three times some months ago to take sketches, though until now I had been busy with other work.

I am writing to you to seek instructions as to how you would like your father portrayed in this portrait. He did not leave me any instructions in that regard, and although I had some starting sense of his character and bearing, it is always best to ask family in such cases. What particular characteristics, moods, achievements, or interests would you like me to include?

As well as that, there is also the possibility of my adding other family members to the painting, if it is something you would like—although your father will remain the key subject. As strange as it sounds, I have several times painted family portraits in memoriam. In such portraits, people need not be portrayed as they are, but rather as they would like to be remembered.

This is not the first time I have had the honour to paint your family. Many years ago, almost 30 years ago now, your father also commissioned me to paint your mother. She had some natural aptitude for painting herself and was very curious about my process. I even gave her a few lessons around that time. I remember her very fondly.

Let me know how I should proceed, and how I might best portray your father.

Yours sincerely,
Augustus Glenford

Epilogue

April 28, 1833

I received the portrait from Mr Glenford today. He came all the way from Birmingham to deliver it. Together we hung it in the gallery ourselves. We took tea and he entertained me with stories of some of the most eccentric characters he had painted, of which my father was not one.

When he had left, I returned to the gallery to take the portrait in once more. This would be it—the final version of him to look upon from this day forth. Mr Glenford reflected what I had asked most exactly, but was I right in what I asked for?

As I contemplated this question, I found myself idly leafing through some of the old documents my aunt had sent over. I shall have to sort them at some point, but as she said, all are old, none are urgent. Between receipts and reminders, invoices and lists of errands, I stumbled across an old letter, and was surprised to find a familiar handwriting that lingered on the edge of my memory. This letter was written by my mother...

[One letter sits upon the desk, it has aged with time. There are three postmarks that read Habershire OC14 1812, A.OC16.1812, 12o'Clock.Oc.12.1812. Na, and there is a charge mark of 8. It is addressed to Getrude Allington, 6 Chesterfield St, Mayfair, London.]

Although she cannot receive it, perhaps I shall write one more letter in reply before I give my writing desk a much needed reprieve.

Final Letter

[Written in a once black ink that has grown rust coloured with, some of the pages is stained with watercolours. The handwriting is a nostalgic one, an easy and earnest hand slanted in a similar angle to Nicholas', but without any of his sharp urgency.]

Habershire, Oct 14th 1812.

My dearest Gertrude,

I hope you and the children are having a wonderful time in London! I've written a little letter for them which I have enclosed within—I know I could simply have written a postscript, but there was something delightful about sending them proper mail (complete with one of Thomas' silly wax seals) so that they might, at ages two and six, finally know the joy of correspondence. I cannot say that I credit your claim that you miss the company of such small creatures now your William is gone away to school, but I know Agatha and Nicholas will appreciate their adventures in town.

Sadly, however, your efforts to orchestrate some alone time for Thomas and myself did not bear fruit, as one day after the children left his unit was called to the Iberian Peninsula by Col. Weatherton. I did honour your ambitions by taking tea in the gallery with his portrait, which, painted as it was when he inherited Eadly at twenty-two, is quite out of date.

I have now been four days alone at Eadly and the experience has been overwhelmingly strange. I keep imagining I hear Nicholas' little footsteps scurrying down to the kitchen in search of leftover cake (he has no concept that I know of his night time activities!), or Agatha's little sighs when the largest cup in her cup collection will not fit inside the smallest one. Thomas is too irregularly present for me to imagine him, but I miss him nevertheless.

On the first day of my solitude I was very busy indeed, and achieved more in the way of organising, rearranging, and accounting than I had in the entire month prior. On the second day I had done it all, all of it, everything, and so after a walk to Milcot town and back I found myself opening Nicholas' children's watercolour set. Suddenly it was three days later, and I had painted, it appeared, every angle of Eadly Hall with a shilling children's colour box—and let me tell you these paints do not blend with the ease one might desire! I'm not quite sure what is keeping me at it, yet I do not intend to halt my forward march into speculative art—quite the opposite. In fact I have commandeered the hill near the garden for the express purpose of painting this place from above. Eadly and its looming halls as a small speck in a valley of rolling green, quite the novelty!

There's nothing like being alone to surprise oneself utterly. I do really think that one ought to know who they are, who they truly are, when no one else is present. There must be a self we can turn to when there is no one around we need care for. So I shall dedicate my solitude to the spirited examination of my own character. And to planning one or two things for the children's return—after all, Agatha simply cannot turn three without an appropriate to-do! My fondest love to you and the children, you must tell me all you have been up to.

Yours with affection,
Olivia Lockley

THE END

Habershire, 1832. When her father passes away after a long and lingering illness, Agatha Lockley is alone in her childhood home of Eadly Hall. Eadly's heir, her older brother Nicholas, is nowhere to be found, and she is left to manage the future of the estate and the heavy weight of grief. As she sorts through the effects of a distant father, letters old and new reveal family secrets and hidden memories. With the floodgates of the past now open, what will she choose for her future?

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GAME BY HAYLEY GORDON
ILLUSTRATION BY FACHRI MAULANA
COVER DESIGN & LAYOUT BY VEE HENDRO
PUBLISHED BY STORYBREWERS ROLEPLAYING



ISBN 978-1-922917-06-5



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